

## Chapter 40-8

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Liang Shi found a ceramic craft shop on the fifth floor of a shopping mall. After making ceramics here, they could take them home. It supported activities for 1-4 people.

Originally, she had only planned for two people to come, but today they also brought a little child.

Ling Dang had never been to such a place and found everything novel.

After entering, she took the lead in choosing the shape she wanted to make.

The process of making ceramics was a bit like playing with mud. Liang Shi didn't experience the joy of childhood, but instead, because she hadn't completed the last additional task, she worried that something might go wrong again this time, so she kept watching Xu Qingzhu's phone, afraid that someone would call her away again.

The whole process was nerve-wracking.

Most importantly, she had no more chances.

If she didn't complete this task, she would definitely have to accept a misfortune system punishment before accumulating to eighty points and before the next passive task was refreshed.

Xu Qingzhu and Ling Dang played quite well together.

Both were the type with skillful hands, so the simple version of ceramics wasn't difficult for them.

After finishing, the teacher would take them for firing, and they would come back to collect them when the time came.

Seeing that there was still time, the group went to the gaming area on the third floor.

Ling Dang was indeed a serious claw machine<sup>1</sup> enthusiast. She played nearly a hundred coins and caught... three dolls.

Later, it was Liang Shi who mastered the claw machine patterns and managed to catch them efficiently when there weren't many coins left.

But it was enough for Ling Dang to play with.

After catching enough for Ling Dang, Liang Shi asked Xu Qingzhu, "Do you want one?"

Xu Qingzhu's gaze drifted to the claw machine next door, staring at the relatively large Doraemon<sup>2</sup>.

Liang Shi: "..."

She coughed lightly, "I think it would be more cost-effective for us to buy a new one, don't you think?"

Xu Qingzhu said seriously, "I think so too."

So they unanimously headed to the toy store and bought a big Doraemon.

Ling Dang looked at the small toy in her hands: "..."

Suddenly it wasn't appealing anymore.

When the time came, they went to collect the fired ceramics and decided to go eat on the top floor of the mall.

But on the way to the elevator area, Xu Qingzhu suddenly tugged at Liang Shi's sleeve.

Liang Shi asked: "What's wrong?"

"Over there." Xu Qingzhu pointed in a direction. Liang Shi looked in that direction and saw Mrs. Qi and—Qi Jiao.

"Mrs. Qi." Xu Qingzhu said: "That woman who was inexplicably strange last time."

Liang Shi frowned, thinking about the relationship between those two people.

Mrs. Qi and Qi Jiao walked side by side. Qi Jiao's expression was timid and cowering, looking like a soulless puppet with the strings controlling her held in Mrs. Qi's hands.

Mrs. Qi was as always, dressed in designer brands, wearing a water-blue qipao<sup>3</sup> that looked out of place in this modern building.

Mrs. Qi, Jiaojiao, Qi Jiao—

Xu Qingzhu asked: "Do you think that's the Jiaojiao she mentioned?"

Liang Shi nodded: "Yes."

"How do you know?" Xu Qingzhu was surprised.

"That's my colleague's child's teacher." Liang Shi said: "Her name is Qi Jiao."

"Do she and I look alike?" Xu Qingzhu was puzzled, "We're obviously very different."

"Not alike." Liang Shi said.

Ling Dang suddenly said: "Eh? Isn't that Grandma Qi?"

Liang Shi and Xu Qingzhu both crouched down at the same time, "You know her?"

Ling Dang nodded, "She often comes to our house to play mahjong<sup>4</sup> with Grandma. Aunt Qi Jiao also comes often."

"Has she ever hit you?" Liang Shi immediately asked.

For some reason, after seeing Mrs. Qi, she felt an inexplicable sense of oppression in her heart.

She always felt that the scene from that night would repeat itself.

In that dark small room, she was being disciplined and beaten.

And the little child with her didn't even dare to cry.

Just thinking about it made her feel like she couldn't breathe.

She was afraid that Ling Dang had also suffered such things.

Ling Dang shook her head, "Why would she hit me? My mom would never let her hit me."

Liang Shi: "..."

She felt inexplicably stabbed.

Liang Shi asked again: "Does she have any strange behaviors?"

"Not really." Ling Dang said, then suddenly paused, "Does it count that she often hits Aunt Qi Jiao?"

Ling Dang was afraid of being overheard, so she lowered her voice extremely low, leaning between the two of them to whisper, "Last time I saw Aunt Qi Jiao's body was covered in pinch marks, and whenever Grandma Qi gets unhappy, she slaps Aunt Qi Jiao. And once, when I went in to play with Grandma, Aunt Qi Jiao was kneeling on a nail board."

"Nail board?!" Liang Shi and Xu Qingzhu gasped.

"Not the sharp side." Ling Dang said: "Just the flat side, with several rows of nails. Aunt Qi Jiao's face was completely pale, and her tears reached here."

She even demonstrated as she spoke, "But Grandma Qi wouldn't let her cry, saying that if tears fell, she would flip the nail board over and make her kneel on it."

Liang Shi & Xu Qingzhu: "..."

Ah, this.

Ling Dang continued: "But Grandma Qi also often has wounds on her body. She's come to our house several times with bruises on her face."

Liang Shi: "..."

Ling Dang glanced at Xu Qingzhu, then secretly crawled to Liang Shi's ear to whisper, "Auntie, you also need to be careful of Grandma Qi."

"Why?" Liang Shi asked.

"Last time when Aunt Qi Jiao was kneeling on the nail board, Grandma Qi said she would keep that thing at our house." Ling Dang swallowed nervously but still continued: "She said if you don't behave, she'll have Grandma make you kneel on that nail board."

Liang Shi: "..."

Are these people crazy?

Ling Dang sighed, "I've had nightmares about that for several nights."

But she was like a little adult, "I had Grandma throw that thing away, so don't be afraid, no one will bully you."

Liang Shi: "..."

Her emotions suddenly reached a critical point, and tears suddenly fell, as if this sentence had crossed twenty years, with Ling Dang comforting that little child from back then.

She said—don't be afraid, no one will bully you.

Liang Shi's heart was inexplicably touched.

Xu Qingzhu handed her tissues.

A moment later, learning from Ling Dang's example, she reached out and patted Liang Shi's shoulder: "Don't worry, I'll protect you from now on. No one will bully you."

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#### Footnotes:

<sup>1</sup> **Claw machine:** Also known as crane games or UFO catchers, these are arcade games where players use a mechanical claw to try to grab prizes, very popular in Asia.

<sup>2</sup> **Doraemon:** A famous Japanese manga and anime character - a blue robotic cat from the future. Very popular throughout Asia as both entertainment and merchandise.

<sup>3</sup> **Qipao:** A traditional Chinese dress, also known as cheongsam, characterized by a high collar, fitted silhouette, and side slits.

<sup>4</sup> **Mahjong:** A traditional Chinese tile-based game commonly played by four people, very popular among middle-aged and elderly people in China as a social activity.